Arcadia Impact AI Governance Taskforce Autumn 2026 cohort projects

Project overviews and applicant guidance

About

This document gives an outline of the research project options for the Autumn 2026 cohort of the AI Governance Taskforce. The details given are the high-level overviews. Our Research Team Leaders (RTLs) work with our expert partners to develop detailed tightly scoped research questions and plans for each of these projects during the run-up to the cohort start.

For queries, please email: Ben R Smith, Taskforce Lead - ben [at] arcadiaimpact [dot] org
Please do not contact our expert partners or RTLs directly at this point.

What we look for in Research Associate participants

Beyond the requirements listed for the first stage general application, our projects have specific requirements which we assess against at the second application stage prior to making decisions to invite to interview (the final stage). These projects benefit from a range of different skillsets and transferable expertise. Each project overview below lists the specific essential and desirable knowledge, skills and expertise required across the 4 participants that will form each project team under the Research Team Lead, and guided by our expert partners. Teams of Research Associate participants will be carefully selected to balance multi-disciplinary complimentary skills, expertise and experience. It is important that projects both have a strong theoretical basis as appropriate and produce accessible, actionable policy recommendations for a range of suitable stakeholders, policymakers or decision makers. Some of these projects will require some specialist technical and non-technical expertise, but all require a general need for a pragmatic policy focus and clear, focussed communication to target audiences. Note that even the more technical projects require a non-technical perspective and vice-versa.

Applying for projects

You will list your first choice project on the application form for this round, and rank further choices. We commit to assessing you for your first choice only, we will only consider you for other projects at our discretion. Only submit ONE form for this round.

Project list and overviews are below

Project list

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Summary table and notes:

Expert partner	Project	Stage and level
José Villalobos, FLI	Mapping state perspectives on digital sovereignty and advanced AI access	Cross-cutting: international context and institutions
Sean McGregor, AVERI	Litigation exposure when AI audits AI	Pre-deployment assurance: legal design for third-party audit
Markov Grey, CeSIA	Risk modelling of AI-enabled harmful manipulation in the political domain	Pre-deployment risk acceptance: EU AI Office and GPAI providers
Marta Bieńkiewicz, CAIF	Risk escalation and thresholds for multi-agent AI	Post-deployment monitoring: ecosystem scale, regulators and standards bodies
Heather Frase, VerAItech	Governance responses to early warning signs of AI cascades	Post-deployment response: single organisation, high-consequence sectors
Isaak Mengesha, Oxford INET / Apollo Research	Capability planning under deep uncertainty for advanced AI risks	Crisis preparedness: national government

A note on the Marta Bieńkiewicz (CAIF) and Heather Frase (VerAItech) projects

Whilst similar as both concern failures that spread through interacting AI agents faster than people can respond, they are distinct and separate projects. The Marta Bieńkiewicz (CAIF) project, led by Michael Harré, is about detection: what to measure across a population of agents, and at what trigger level; the Heather Frase (VerAItech) project, led by Omar Beno, is about response: once a warning appears inside one organisation's own workflows, what it means, what to do and who decides.

Project overviews

José Villalobos (FLI)

The Future of Life Institute (FLI) - Multilateral Governance Lead

Research Team Leader: Josephine Schwab

Mapping state perspectives on digital sovereignty and advanced AI access

Problem Statement

Three areas are emerging in international discussion on governing advanced AI: AI red lines or prohibitions as a combination of standards and verifiable capability thresholds; emergency response and incident sharing; and concerns about digital sovereignty, advanced model access, and benefit sharing. The first two can be specified with some degree of precision, but the third is much more diffuse. When states say they wish to preserve their "digital sovereignty" – whether they wish to reduce dependency on the United States and China, to build their own AI stack, or ensure they are not left behind – they appear to mean a range of different things, and it is not entirely clear whether those meanings share a common core, or whether they converge or diverge by region, economic position, participation in the AI supply chain, or other factors.

Sovereignty and advanced AI access are issues that are frequently raised together, and the relationship between them can be understood in a number of ways: sovereignty as governing how advanced AI is developed, given that systems built abroad still have domestic effects; access as a substitute for sovereignty; sovereignty as exercised over access to advanced AI and to other indirect benefits from it; or access as a vector of dependency, since whoever grants the access can also withdraw it. While advanced AI development remains concentrated, most states encounter it on terms that are set elsewhere. This project seeks to make a conceptual contribution to this discussion through a clear framework or concept capable of holding these perspectives together, offering a usable shared vocabulary that may be adopted by states and by those working with them in international fora. The research will also consider what such a framework implies for the design of international institutions and coordinated measures that would be needed to act on what these states say they want, and is likely to have a strong AI middle-powers focus.

Preliminary Research Questions

What do states mean when they invoke "digital sovereignty" in relation to advanced AI, and what have they proposed or adopted in response? How does digital sovereignty relate to access to advanced AI, and on what terms can states participate in access regimes they did not design, including those justified by national security and those built for the management of catastrophic risk?

Outputs

● **x2 Policy briefs**: The intention is 1) one short brief suitable for circulation in UN and other international AI governance fora (distilled findings and terminology); 2) one longer brief targeted at policy researchers and governance practitioners (the mapping along with the framework and its analytical basis)

Knowledge, skills and experience required on the team
(Note, a team of four will be formed, applicants do not need to fulfill all the below criteria)

Essential (collectively covered across the team):

- Demonstrated experience conducting systematic reviews of academic literature, policy, or government material.
- Ability to work with primary sources, involving: reading national strategies, ministerial statements and multilateral communiqués, distinguishing declaratory positions from adopted measures, and synthesising across inconsistent sources.
- Comfort with conceptual and definitional work: building, testing, revising typologies.
- Understanding of the geopolitical and economic context of advanced AI, including the concentration of development and the structure of the supply chain.
- Clear, structured, written communication, in styles suitable for research-, policy- and governance-facing audiences.

Desirable (collectively covered across the team):

- Familiarity with debates on digital sovereignty, strategic autonomy, or benefit sharing concerning advanced AI.
- Familiarity with policy materials in other languages besides English.
- Familiarity with international institutional design, whether through research or professional practice, including how mandates, membership and funding arrangements are settled in multilateral bodies.
- Familiarity with qualitative research methods, particularly comparative case study, discourse or content analysis.

Sean McGregor (AVERI)

AI Verification & Evaluation Research Institute (AVERI) - Co-Founder & Lead Research Engineer

Research Team Leader: Michael Celone

Litigation Exposure When AI Audits AI: Aligning Incentives for Candid Third-Party Audits

Third-party safety audits are becoming the de facto mechanism for safeguarding frontier AI development. They are a feature of nearly every AI safety governance proposal, including Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei's recent call to embed outside evaluators inside frontier labs.

Given the scale and complexity of the models under review, third-party auditors must increasingly rely on AI tools of their own. Yet as frontier labs face increasing litigation following AI incidents, these machine-generated audit records are becoming critical evidence that could help establish products liability. And while a *human* auditor's communications with the lab's counsel might be shielded from disclosure, the underlying (and far more valuable) AI-generated records are likely to be treated as ordinary business records that could be subpoenaed in later litigation. This creates a perverse incentive for frontier labs to limit the deep, non-public access a rigorous audit requires, and can have a chilling effect on auditors from fully documenting their important deliberations.

The core problem is therefore one of incentive alignment: rigorous safety audits are dependent on deep access granted by the frontier labs; yet those labs will grant deep access only if they (and their auditors) can trust that fulsome, AI-assisted audit records will not inadvertently become evidence (at scale) against them in court. Working with the AI Verification and Evaluation Research Institute (AVERI), this project will analyze how courts are likely to treat machine-generated audit records and, where existing law falls short, draw lessons from other safety-critical industries to propose legal and policy approaches for protecting third-party auditors' safety work product.

Knowledge, skills and experience required on the team
(Note, a team of four will be formed, applicants do not need to fulfill all the below criteria)

Essential (collectively covered across the 4-person team)

- Experience with AI evaluation, auditing, or testing, or with testing, evaluation, safety or compliance audits in any safety-critical domain (at least one person)
- Familiarity with legal or policy analysis, including reading statutes, regulations, or court opinions (at least one person)
- Familiarity with systems thinking, including incentive design or causal loop modeling
- Strong analytical and synthesis skills, including turning technical and legal material into clear, policy-relevant insights
- Clear, structured written communication for technical, legal, and policy audiences

Desirable (collectively covered across the 4-person team)

- Legal education or experience with litigation, discovery, compliance, or regulation
- Experience developing or drafting policy or legislation at any level, whether corporate, local, or national
- Familiarity with behavioral economics concepts such as principal-agent problems
- Deeper expertise or extensive experience in any of the above areas

Markov Grey (1, 2) (CeSIA)

Centre pour la Sécurité de l'IA (CeSIA) - Head of Technical Governance

Research Team Leader: Yohan Mathew

Risk Modelling of AI-enabled Harmful Manipulation in the Political Domain

Frontier AI companies and regulators rely on dangerous-capability evaluations to decide whether a model can be deployed and with what safeguards, but going from evaluation results to determining acceptable levels of real-world risk is still largely driven by subjective judgement. The Safety and Security chapter of the EU's General-Purpose AI Code of Practice names harmful manipulation as one of four systemic risks (Appendix 1.4) that providers of the most capable models must identify, analyze and determine risk acceptance for (Commitments 2, 3, 4). Safety-critical industries such as aviation and nuclear power bridge this gap with explicit risk models, and recent work has attempted to apply this approach to AI-enabled cyber threats by linking benchmark results to step-by-step attack pathways and estimates of real-world harm.

This project seeks to adapt that risk-modelling methodology to AI-enabled harmful manipulation with a focus on the political domain, such as influence operations targeting elections or public debate. See here and here for some related writing.
The project is likely to include some combination of the following:

- Defining what the appropriate metric for real-world harm would be in the case of political manipulation (for example, degradation of "empowered voters");
- Breaking down how interactions with AI systems and/or actions taken by AI systems can lead to political manipulation, and in turn defining a set of relevant scenarios;
- Mapping each scenario as a causal pathway from AI capability to real-world harm, along with the transition probabilities at each step;
- Analyzing the contributions to overall risk from various nodes in the graph to identify high-leverage intervention points;

- Understanding how the risk profiles vary for different models/systems and providers to enable decisions about their deployment within the EU in accordance with the Act.

The primary output will be a research pre-print or policy report describing a part or whole of the set of political manipulation risk models and a shorter accessible piece summarizing key takeaways from our research. This would be a component of a larger set of risk models being developed, visualized and disseminated by CeSIA on harmful manipulation across multiple domains, which in turn may feed into the evaluation and enforcement of GPAI models and providers by the EU AI Office.

Knowledge, skills and experience required on the team
(Note: a team of four will be formed. Applicants do not need to meet all the criteria below.)

Essential (collectively covered across the team):

- Familiarity with quantitative risk assessment or probabilistic modelling, e.g. Bayesian networks, fault or event trees, Monte carlo methods, DBBNs (dynamic bayesian belief networks), and ABMs (agent based models) (at least one person).
- Knowledge of political persuasion, disinformation, or influence operations, from research, journalism, OSINT or trust & safety work (at least one person).
- Familiarity (not necessarily as a practitioner) with AI evaluations, ideally including persuasion, manipulation or social-behaviour evaluations, or red-teaming (at least one person).
- Strong analytical and communication skills, including turning technical material into clear, policy-relevant insights.

Desirable (collectively covered across the team):

- Hands-on experience with AI evaluations, including persuasion, manipulation or social-behaviour evaluations, or red-teaming (at least one person).
- Background in political science, social or cognitive psychology, communication studies, or computational social science (e.g. agent-based modelling or social network simulation).
- Familiarity with risk management practice in safety-critical industries (aviation, nuclear, cybersecurity) or with frontier AI safety frameworks.
- Familiarity with the EU AI Act, the General-Purpose AI Code of Practice, or the Digital Services Act.

Marta Bieńkiewicz (CAIF)

Cooperative AI Foundation (CAIF) - Policy & Partnerships Manager

Research Team Leader: Michael Harré

Risk Escalation and Thresholds for Multi-Agent AI

Multi-agent safety thresholds and governance do not carry over directly from single-agent settings. Even when individual agents pass a pre-release audit, new risks such as miscoordination, conflict, and collusion appear once AIs begin to interact with one another. As automated systems interact at machine speed, risk factors amplify into systemic failures before humans can respond. We will look at existing methods in fields such as power grids, traffic engineering, financial markets, and air traffic control and evaluate their applicability for multi-agent AI risk escalation and thresholds. The CAIF/Brookings IASEAI memo (Establishing Foundational Principles and Thresholds for Multi-Agent AI Governance) sets out five governance actions - Evaluate, Identify, Monitor, Report, Incentivise - but only “Monitor" already exists as mature regulation with a track record in financial markets.

This project will look at governance mechanisms and emergent AI risks from fields that already manage networks of interacting, potentially destabilising, agents. Their central lesson - stability by monitoring *collective behaviour* rather than inspecting individual agents - will be assessed against measures that increase as risk escalates. A set of candidate observables such as behavioural clustering and divergences, feedback loops, and behavioural drift will be proposed against which escalation can be assessed and thresholds proposed. The project will turn these lessons into concrete threshold design principles: The quantity measured, the trigger level, who sets it, and how it varies by agent archetype and context. The primary output is a working paper or preprint for technical and policy audiences, with a short-form version for a tech-policy venue.

Knowledge, skills and experience required on the team

(Note: a team of four will be formed; applicants do not need to fulfil all of the criteria below.)

Essential (collectively covered across the team):

- Familiarity (practitioner experience is not necessary) with AI evaluation, safety thresholds, or multi-agent evaluation methods (at least one person)

- Technical understanding of AI/ML agentic systems, including agent properties such as planning, reasoning, tool use, memory, and multi-agent interaction dynamics (at least one person)
- Working knowledge of financial-market microstructure and/or the regulation of algorithmic and high-frequency trading: circuit breakers, kill switches, market surveillance, and post-incident reforms (at least one person)
- Familiarity with AI governance, incident-reporting, or international-coordination (at least one person)
- Strong analytical and synthesis skills, including turning technical material into clear, policy-relevant insight
- Clear, structured written communication suitable for both technical and policy audiences, produced on a tight timeline
- Comfort working with a multidisciplinary team: technical, economic, and governance registers, including under conditions of incomplete or evolving information

Desirable (collectively covered across the team):

- Quantitative or computational methods: time-series analysis, agent-based modelling, or multi-agent simulation
- Prior experience with algorithmic collusion, market-microstructure, or systemic-risk / macroprudential modelling
- Hands-on experience with multi-agent evaluation, sandboxing, or red teaming
- Familiarity with governance analogues in other safety-critical, tightly coupled domains (energy grids, payment systems, aviation autonomy, or similar)
- Familiarity with standards bodies or international AI governance work
- Legal or regulatory background relevant to cross-jurisdictional oversight, accountability, or triggers

Heather Frase (1,2) (VerAItech)

CEO, VerAItech

Research Team Leader: Omar Beno

Governance responses to early warning signs of AI cascades

As organisations give AI agents access to tools, data and connected workflows, a problem in one part of a system may spread into other agents, information or downstream actions. Current research is beginning to identify signals that can reveal this kind of propagation, while major technology and cyber-security organisations are developing monitoring, containment and incident-response practices for agentic AI. However, an alert does not necessarily tell an organisation what caused the problem, how far it has spread, which action would stop it, or who should be authorised to intervene. This project focuses on response within an individual deploying organisation's own agentic workflows, distinct from proposals aimed at frontier model developers or regulators overseeing a wider ecosystem, and from cross-organisational or third-party deployments.

This project will examine what different early warning signs actually tell an organisation and what further information is needed before different responses are appropriate. It will consider actions ranging from further investigation and restricting particular tools or permissions through to isolating an agent or pausing a wider workflow. The research will also examine who needs to monitor the system, who should make and authorise response decisions, who can technically carry them out, and what evidence should be required before normal operation resumes. The work will be grounded in examples drawn from high-consequence settings (for example finance, healthcare, energy or critical national infrastructure), where uncontained propagation has a plausible route to systemic harm.

The team will review the available technical research and any operational documentation that exists, drawing on incident-response practice from adjacent domains (cybersecurity, financial operations, industrial control systems) where direct evidence from agentic deployments is not yet available. It will compare these findings with established incident-response practice, using examples drawn from published evidence to illustrate the decisions involved and challenge the analysis. The project will not develop a new detector or prescribe universal numerical thresholds; the main output will be a research paper with a practical supplementary table linking warning evidence to possible responses, their requirements and the responsibilities involved.

Knowledge, skills and experience sought
Applicants do not need to meet every criterion; the aim is to combine complementary strengths across the team.

Essential (collectively covered across the team)

- Technical understanding of AI agents and agentic workflows, sufficient to interpret technical research, including tool use, information sharing and monitoring
- Experience / familiarity in operational resilience, incident response, security operations, or another field concerned with responding to failures in live systems
- Familiarity with AI governance, assurance, organisational risk or related governance and control questions
- Strong research, critical analysis and synthesis skills, including the ability to distinguish what evidence demonstrates from what it suggests
- Clear written communication and the ability to work collaboratively

Desirable(collectively covered across the team)

- Experience with post-deployment AI monitoring, AI evaluation, cyber security, safety engineering or agent systems
- Comfort assessing whether a proposed monitoring metric or signal is well-supported by evidence, as distinct from plausible but unvalidated
- Comfort inspecting technical traces, public datasets or basic code
- Experience analysing incidents or operational controls
- Experience in high-consequence or regulated organisations (for example financial services, healthcare, energy or government)

Software engineering, statistics and machine-learning training experience are not required.

Isaak Mengesha (1,2) (Oxford/Apollo Research)

Oxford University- Postdoctoral Research Associate, Oxford Martin Programme & Institute for New Economic Thinking (INET); Apollo Research - Member of Governance Staff (incoming)

Research Team Leader: Charlie Collins

Capability Planning Under Deep Uncertainty for Advanced AI Risks

This project aims to identify the gap between the capabilities required for handling an advanced AI crisis ("the capability target") and the capabilities governments currently hold ("current capability"). It picks up from a previous AI Governance Taskforce cohort project and focuses on substantiating the capability target through a Delphi study with subject-matter experts (SMEs).

Why this matters

The future of advanced AI is highly uncertain, spanning a broad range of possible paths, some of which pose severe risks. Governments typically prioritise risk mitigation, including capability-building, by likelihood and impact. But AI defies prediction: experts' timelines differ by orders of magnitude, dangerous capabilities emerge abruptly, and failure modes surprise even their developers. When predictions fail, preparations designed around specific risks fail with them, and the "predict-then-act" paradigm breaks down.

Governments have faced "deep uncertainty" before. Certain defence, flood and financial supervisory policies no longer prepare for a single predicted future but build capabilities that protect across many. This works because capabilities remain definable even when accurate risk assessment is impossible. Governments have yet to apply this thinking to advanced AI; this project is a step towards doing so.

What the project involves

The project builds on a previous AI Governance Taskforce cohort project (also primarily focused on the capability target), in which a cohort devised a lightweight, proof-of-concept method for applying "decision making under deep uncertainty" (DMDU) principles to government capability planning for advanced AI risks. This produced a systematically-varied scenario library, a capability library, and manual ratings of 15 capabilities against the scenarios.

Core deliverable: a two-round Delphi study with Subject-Matter Experts (SMEs) will substantiate the capability ratings, broadened to the full library. Its analysis and presentation will form the minimum viable product (MVP), extending the previous cohort's methods paper into a results paper.

In parallel: in preparation for the results of the Delphi study, the team will process the previous cohort's results, maximising their explanatory yield and developing and calibrating a method for automating capability ratings.

Beyond the MVP: time (and ambition) permitting, the team can take on other problems relevant to understanding and communicating the capability gap.

Knowledge, skills and experience required on the team
(Note: a team of four will be formed, applicants do not need to fulfill all the below criteria)

Essential (collectively covered across the 4-person team):

- Familiarity with the AI policy landscape and current debates around frontier AI risk, sufficient to engage credibly with government audiences and get up to speed quickly on risks under study (loss of control, power concentration, cyberattacks and CBRN/biosecurity).
- Working knowledge of AI capabilities and how they are currently evaluated and forecast, sufficient to interpret a capability rating and judge whether it is technically and practically credible.
- Experience or knowledge of practical functioning of Western government structures, legal authorities, regulation and risk assessment processes to contextualise capability ratings and assessments.
- Strong written communication aimed at non-academic, non-technical readers, with the ability to produce concise, decision-relevant outputs.
- Experience or transferable quantitative skills relevant to the processing of structured survey or rating data, and visualisation and presentation of results (can be built up during the project/augmented by LLM assistance etc.).
- Comfort with ambiguity and with documenting uncertainty and assumptions plainly.

Desirable (collectively covered across the 4-person team):

- Experience in a government department, regulator, or policy institute, with a practical understanding of how risk assessments and scenarios are conducted and used.
- Experience in, or working knowledge of, scenario planning, capability-based planning or capability-assessment frameworks in a high-stakes domain (national risk registers, financial stress testing, pandemic preparedness, defence wargaming, climate scenarios, or similar).
- Understanding of how government capabilities are actually built, funded and held (institutions, legal authorities, workforce, infrastructure etc.).
- Experience designing and running a Delphi study: instrument design, rating scales, feedback between rounds, and consensus and stability criteria.

- Experience working with structured survey or rating data and applying statistical methods such as consensus and agreement measures.
- Experience using LLMs for structured judgement tasks: prompt and rubric design, structured outputs, and calibrating automated ratings against human ratings, including validation design, agreement metrics, error analysis and known LLM-as-judge biases.
- Experience designing audit or assessment instruments (e.g. WHO joint external evaluation, JEE) and evidence-scoring protocols.